a precursor to a larger US attack crippling the nation's command and control capabilities.

Yeltsin's senior officers had ten minutes to decide if the missile was real and headed toward Moscow. If they couldn't determine the trajectory with confidence, they would have to make a recommendation, and Yeltsin, whose nuclear briefcase was open and ready, would have had to make the ultimate decision. It took eight minutes before the air defense officials decided the missile was headed out to open sea rather than to the Russian capital. Within hours, they discovered that the missile was a joint Norwegian-US scientific mission to study the aurora borealis. The United States had properly notified Moscow of the test, but that information had not been passed down to the Russian radar operators.[17]

If loyalty to or fear of Kim is as strong as most outside observers believe it to be, nuance during a crisis is likely to be lost on Kim's senior officers. Instead, there is every reason to suspect that a combination of self-preservation, ideological fervor, and even true loyalty would predispose Kim's officers to nuclear aggressiveness. The fate of Asia may rest on whether North Korea has its own Stanislav Petrov.

VII.

Safety for the North Korean nuclear arsenal will rest primarily with Kim Jong-un and his officers. One can only hope they have studied, or at least are aware of, the accidents that plagued the United States and Russia. If they adopt a cavalier attitude or are focused on avoiding responsibility and redirecting any blame, then standards, confidence, and professionalism will be the first casualty. As Haney noted, it all comes down to their perceptions of the importance of the mission. Will Kim and his lieutenants take seriously the responsibility of nuclear surety, or will each be focused on his own political reputation?

Living in this new environment will demand new, perhaps radical thinking on the part of the United States government. Though bizarre